SpeechGeek



Season Eight: Fall 2010

SpeechGeek

ISSN 1545-9209 Price $25 US
http://www.speechgeek.com

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ISSN 1545-9209

Corey Alderdice
Editor and Publisher

Email:
thegeek@speechgeek.com

806 Brownstone Way
Bowling Green, KY 42104
(270) 705-3632

SpeechGeek is published four times per year: August, October, December, and April by Corey Alderdice, 806 Brownstone Way, Bowling Green, Kentucky 42104. Special issues are published from time to time.

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Corey Alderdice
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Science: No Boys Allowed

by Jane Nicolaas

BOTH. Ladies and Gentlemen. Girls and – ick – boys.
INA. Allow me to welcome you to the 5th grade science fair at Pinedale Independent School District.
ANGELICA. Where science gets PISD! (*to be pronounced "pissed"*)
INA. Now that you've seen the rest of the exhibitions, it's time for the best of the exhibitions…mine!
ANGELICA. Ours!
INA. (*begrudgingly*) Ours. My name is Ina Stein. And that is my lab assistant…and little sister…Angelica.
ANGELICA. It means Angel-like.
INA. Pay no attention to her. As a 3rd grader, she is ineligible for the grand prize fifty-pound chocolate bar.
ANGELICA. Wait, you never said—
INA. We are here to change the future!
ANGELICA. Change the future!
INA. We are here to forget the past.
ANGELICA. What past?
INA. We are opening the present.
ANGELICA. Like Christmas morning!
INA. We are going to kill our lab assistant if she keeps making colorful commentary.
ANGELICA. Sorry.
INA. Ladies and gentlemen, we are ready to astonish, amaze, and astound you...
BOTH. With science.

INTRO

INA. Angelica, I must prepare the device. Please continue the presentation… and no tangents!
ANGELICA. Okay. Hi, everyone. Hi, Peter!
INA. Angelica!
ANGELICA. Okay! (*reads from note cards*) Ah-hem. The illustrated…
INA. …*Illustrious…*
ANGELICA. Are you telling the story, or am I? Sheesh. The illustrious experiment in genetic modification and behavioral correction began four weeks ago in an Isaac Newton sort of…wait a minute. This isn't right. (*throws the note cards away*). If you wanna know the truth it all started on the most celebrated…
INA. …Massacre…
ANGELICA. …holiday in February…Valentine's Day!

TRANSITION

INA. …It's an awful, antiquated, and ridiculous ritual! Heart-shaped cards and candy? This is not an accurate representation of a heart, and…

ANGELICA. (*enters carrying an enormous box of valentines*) …They're pretty.

INA. Dear, little sister. Do not be wooed by Hallmark and Hersheys. These classmates of yours… these Neanderthals… these…

ANGELICA. Boys!

INA. Are clearly a genetically inferior species incapable of recognizing greatness.

ANGELICA. You sound like a women's studies major.

INA. I mean, how else do you explain my drought of love requests and tokens of affection?

ANGELICA. … (*thinks really hard*)

INA. Shut-up.

ANGELICA. Well, maybe you should fix them.

INA. Who?

ANGELICA. Boys.

INA. Little sister, you're brilliant!

ANGELICA. I am?

INA. For the moment. Come! To the laboratory!

ANGELICA. To the garage!

INA. The moment is over.

TRANSITION

INA. Yes…when I look back now, it seems to me as if this almost miraculous event obliterated any last effort by the spirit of preservation to avert the storm that was even then hanging in the stars.

ANGELICA. What?

INA. We went to the garage to start the experiment.

TRANSITION

ANGELICA. So you're going to fix boys so they make you valentines? Maybe you should just try some makeup…

INA. This isn't about cards and candy.

ANGELICA. It isn't?

INA. Okay, it isn't *just* about cards and candy. This is a chance for us to fix what's wrong with society and make the world a better place.

ANGELICA. I thought we were going to fix boys?

INA. Try not to be so shortsighted—

ANGELICA. I'm near-sighted, not shortsighted…stupid. And anyway, what about Daddy? We don't need to fix him, do we?

INA. No. Mom says he's already been fixed. (*They both have no idea what that means.*) For now, we will focus our efforts on the youth of the male species.

ANGELICA. But how are we going to study them? They won't come over to the house anymore. Not since you permanently removed John Saunder's eyebrows with your—

INA. That hair remover was brilliance!

ANGELICA. But you *meant* for it to be a hiccup remover.

INA. Hmmm…well this time will be different. We will study our subjects carefully.

ANGELICA. And then?

INA. And then we will analyze the data and construct our machine.

ANGELICA. And then?

INA. And then we will conduct our experiment live at the science fair. It will be brilliant! Yes, our perfect prototype will be a product of precision…

ANGELICA. Prestige!

INA. Perfection!

ANGELICA. Pistachios!

INA. Pistachios! Wait…what?

ANGELICA. I thought we were naming "P" words.

INA. You are a plague (*pops the "P" sound*) on my creative genius.

ANGELICA. Which also starts with "P".

TRANSITION

INA. Needless to say, we were faced with obstacles: the first of which was our lack of research subjects.

ANGELICA. They all ran when they saw her coming.

INA. So we decided to study them in their natural habitat. We traversed to their metaphorical watering hole.

ANGELICA. I thought we went to the baseball field?

TRANSITION

ANGELICA. (*hiding in the bushes*) I'll take notes.

INA. Very good. But no hearts above the "I's". Title: Observations About – ick – Boys. Initial reaction: Subjects seem to have a propensity for balls.

ANGELICA. Ha…Ha…Ha… (*giggles*)

INA. What? They are playing with balls. Recommendation: alter their frontal lobe cortex to respond more affectionately to a wider variety of stimuli: art, science, literature, classical music, and dolls. They shouldn't just play with their balls. Why are you laughing at me? You're being paid to take notes not laugh.

ANGELICA. I'm being paid?

INA. No. Also, physical violence has been misconstrued as a form of

inclusion and affection. Recommendation: rewire the pain-processing center of the brain so as to reverse the mental damage that mistakes pain for pleasure.

ANGELICA. And they spit.

INA. Yes, they spit.

ANGELICA. A lot.

BOTH. Ick.

INA. Note: They may be direct descendents of camels. Recommendation: Fix that.

ANGELICA. So we're going to change what they like, make them more sensitive, and improve their hygiene?

INA. Yes, it sounds like a lot…but really it just takes the proper tool.

ANGELICA. To the laboratory?

INA. Yes! To the garage!

TRANSITION

INA. After a careful and intricate planning phase…

ANGELICA. …Which was a phase that mother mandated after "the cat incident"…

INA. …we decided that it would be best to execute our plan through the clever use of buttons, machines, and, of course, duct tape.

TRANSITION

INA. Yes, tonight we shall ascend into the heavens and we will penetrate into the very womb of nature itself.

ANGELICA. Ew. Are you sure?

INA. Throw the first switch!

ANGELICA. Yes!

INA. Throw the second switch!

ANGELICA. You got it!

INA. Throw the third!

ANGELICA. No, not the third switch…

INA. Throw it I say! (*They begin playing with machines and assembling their invention.*)

INA. Gumdrops and roses, whiskers on kittens…

ANGELICA. …Cream colored ponies and pretty pink mittens! Doorbells and sleigh bells

INA. Doorbells?

ANGELICA. Ok, no doorbells. What about sugar and spice and everything nice?

INA. Very well! (*They continue their construction until it is complete.*) It's flawless. It's brilliant…it's The Perfect Boy Maker! It's…

ANGELICA. Really small. All that work for just that?

INA. Silence or I'll turn it into the Sister-Fixer 9000.

ANGELICA. (*locks her mouth shut and throws away the key*)

INA. And now…we take our place amongst the gods as Science Fair Champions.

TRANSITION

ANGELICA. Which brings us to this moment.

INA. We now require a volunteer. An – ick – boy.

ANGELICA. Peter? Thanks. Come right this way.

INA. Yes, the road has been long and fraught with danger, but we faced it bravely. For the sake of science…and chocolate.

ANGELICA. All ready boss!

INA. And now, the time has come!

BOTH. Ladies and gentlemen! We present, the perfect boy! (*Use the device. Both gasp and look at each other, and then look at Peter again.*)

INA. It's…our perfect…boy?

ANGELICA. But he's a she. Her… him… is a her…the he is a her. She's a former he.

INA. Uh, ladies and gentlemen. It seems…in correcting the errors in the genetic makeup of males we've created…a girl?

ANGELICA. Explains why Eve came second.

INA. But…but…I don't understand. I don't know what to do.

ANGELICA. Don't worry, Sis, I've got this one. Ladies and gentlemen, we have conducted this brave and cutting edge study of culturally and socially constructed behavioral roles to assess the true meaning of gender and its impact on today's youth. We have thusly arrived at an important and groundbreaking experiment that proves a vital truth that we must all understand in order to coexist as kids: the difference between a boy and a girl is not one that a great scientist can fix. It is simply a matter of an open mind and an ability to see beyond spitting habits. In conclusion, I'd like to thank our subject, Peter. I mean…uh…Petra. And I'd like to thank you all in advance for your support and your vote for the exhibition of the year. Thank you and goodnight.

INA. Wow. That was…amazing.

ANGELICA. Thanks. I wrote it ahead of time…just in case.

INA. You know, we probably won't win the chocolate bar.

ANGELICA. I know. That's why I got you this…just in case.

INA. Gee…thanks. What is it?

ANGELICA. It's a valentine. But it's an *accurate* representation of a human heart.

INA. Hmm. You're pretty okay, little sister.

ANGELICA. I am?

INA. For the moment.

Diamond Dreams

by Jane Nicolaas

(Miguel Santana stands in centerfield, lightly tossing and contemplating the base ball in his hand.)

MIGUEL. There are many differences between you and me. Maybe you notice the color of my skin: it's not quite black; it's not quite brown. It's the color of 18 Caribbean summers in a sandlot.

Maybe you notice my accent: it's not quite Mexican; it's not quite Cuban. It's the sound of a Dominican who was raised on bad American movies and meringue. Or maybe you don't see any of that. Maybe you only see this (*shows the ball*). Baseball.

The real difference between you and me is this. You see a sport, a pastime, a game. But to me, this is no game. This is my life.

I have seen those stories on your *National Geographic*. The way America sees the Dominican people; naked babies running in dirty streets with ribcages showing with faces that look like this (*big eyes, cute frown*). It looks like all we do is walk around weeping. The truth is, I don't remember much weeping in my life.

See, maybe I couldn't read or write, but I could run. And when I ran, I could begin to dream. And that dream…well you would call it the American Dream… to escape a life of begging and worrying and make a name for myself. To have enough money to buy my papa a rocking chair, my sisters some fine clothes, and mama a big house. Every time I swung a stick or tree branch in the shape of a bat, I dreamed of that.

My dream is just one of many known only in Spanish in the palm trees and on baseball diamonds of the Caribbean. You see, I was seventeen and earning money for my family wherever I could. Most days I was working in a garment factory, ironing shirts, pressing pants, getting used to my sweat smelling like bleach. But occasionally, when the factory was closed or when the wages were slow, I would shine shoes. That's where I met him.

MIGUEL. *Good afternoon, sir.*
JACK. *Give them a good shine, kid. And be quiet, I got a phone call to make.*

MIGUEL. He was an American businessman, obviously. So I went about my

work quickly; American businessmen mean American dollars. So I shine, and he pulled out one of those little phones that always confuse me. Why do you like your phones so small? And why do you have to talk so loud into them? Maybe if your phones were bigger, you could talk more normal like?

Now, I didn't understand all his words, but I knew enough English to know that this was not a sugar man or a fruit man. This was a *baseball* man.

You see, for as long as I can remember, the Dominican has been like…like a field for growing baseball players. And these men, these major league scouts, come here to harvest.

This, perhaps, seems strange. But Latinos have always been good-looking to scouts because we are…um…cheap labor. Just like so many Latin immigrants in other walks of life, we don't receive much, but we work very, very hard.

So, this man…this scout, sits in my chair talking loudly. And then, as if God himself took pity me, a ball, like this one…rolled next to me on the ground. I look up and see kids, three maybe four hundred feet away from me. I smile and with ease I launch the ball back to them in a perfect arch that almost sings in the humid air. It snaps in the boy's glove and instantly the man in the chair stops talking.

JACK. *Listen, I gotta call you back. (hangs up the phone) Hey, hey Juan…*
MIGUEL. *Me, sir? My name is Miguel.*
JACK. *Right. Whatever. How old are you?*
MIGUEL. *Seventeen.*
JACK. *Hmm, Russell? It's Jack. Ha, yeah, just surveying the livestock. Listen, got a seventeen-year-old here named Manuel.*
MIGUEL. *My name is Miguel.*
JACK. *Shut up. (to phone) You got room for one more at the St. Victoria tryouts? He doesn't look like much, but he's got an arm.*
MIGUEL. *No, sir. I have two of them.*

MIGUEL. What he had meant was that I could throw well. The American baseball man meant I could throw well. It was the kind of thing all Dominican boys want to hear from American scouts. Because someone who can throw might be someone that they can invest in, might someday be a baseball player.

The next day I was told to go to the practice fields outside of St. Victoria. I didn't know how long my family could survive without my wages, but mama told me that we could survive a lot longer if I

became a big shot baseball player. That was mama, always believing I would be the one. She told me I was too strong, too brave, and too hungry not to succeed.

So I went to my tryout. And when I arrived, Mr. Jack was there waiting …and so were many, many other boys who looked just as strong, just as brave, and certainly just as hungry.

JACK. *Hey there, Manuel.*
MIGUEL. *Sir, my name is –*
JACK. *Your name is what I tell you your name is. If you're gonna play for me, you do what I say when I say it. Understand, Manuel?*
MIGUEL. *Yes, sir.*

MIGUEL. I didn't understand, but this is what it means to be a young man in my country: you do what you must to get by. And today that meant we run backwards, we run sideways, we throw and hit and sprint and sweat. For hours different coaches yelled confusing instructions.

JACK. *What do you think will happen if you pull that in the United States? Do you think Mr. Gringo is going to pay to see that?*
MIGUEL. *I'm sorry, Mr. Jack. But I just thought—*
JACK. *You don't think; you do what you're told! If you can't do what I need, there's plenty more shoe shiners who can!*

MIGUEL. Slowly the herd of boys faded away. Some boys were told to leave when they couldn't understand enough English, some were kicked out after they got into fights, and some left when they couldn't run anymore. By sunset it was me and a handful of other boys who were left standing.

Mr. Jack called me over to his side and stared at me for a long time.

JACK. *You're too thin, too small, too uneducated, too unrefined, too unfamiliar with the concept of team, but that right arm of yours is…*
MIGUEL. *Good?*
JACK. *It's enough. I'm giving you an opportunity. I'm going to train you in how to speak, behave, and play like a professional baseball player. You're going to sign this contract and then you're going to play for me every day with every bit of sweat and talent you've got. If you do all that…I can save you from this hellhole you call an island. Sign it, Manuel.*

MIGUEL. And just like that, it was there in front of me: a real professional contract. It was in English and everything! I signed it and with my

two thousand dollars signing bonus, I bought mama some furniture and food for weeks.

I made one hundred dollars a week playing baseball for seven hours a day. In the mornings I would walk or hitchhike to the field and practice for hours while Mr. Jack and the other coaches yelled and cussed and taught me what it means to play the American game. In the afternoon there was a league game that was meant to show us prospects off. Mr. Jack said it was to make money off the local crowds and to keep us sharp for when the coaches from the clubs came to see us play.

At the end of the day I would be drenched in sweat, heavy from fatigue and the humidity. But I was completely ready if Mr. Jack wanted to see three more throws or another at-bat. When the sun set, I would walk or hitchhike home, preparing myself to do it all again the next day.

When Mr. Jack told me that a man named Mr. Cogan was flying from New York City to watch me play, I knew that this was my chance. This was what Mr. Jack had been telling me all along.

JACK. *Now, you just play the way I taught you. This guy, the one who is coming, is going to make your dreams come true, kid. Be here tomorrow at noon.*

MIGUEL. What a saint, Mr. Jack was. What a good man to take such pity on me. Well, I would not let him down. I arrived at the field early, much too early and I sat in the dugout waiting for noon to arrive.

I heard him coming from far away. He was on his little phone again. And he was talking loudly…about me.

JACK. *Yeah, Russell. I'm telling you, the kid is worth millions and I got him for $100 a week. Of course not, they're all the same down here: obedient, dirt-poor, and completely unaware of the money that's coming in. Which, of course, I keep the majority of. Right, our "finder's fee." No, he's a shoe shiner. He won't know the difference. (sees Miguel) Russell, I gotta call you back. (hangs up his phone) Hola.*

MIGUEL. *Millions? I am making just enough money to feed my family and you are making millions? You…you thief. You come to my country—to my home—and think you can just take from hungry and poor kids because we don't know the difference. Well, damn you. I am more than a shoe shiner. I am my mother's son; I am braver, stronger and*

hungrier than any man you have ever known.

JACK. *That may be true son, but this contract says you're mine. See, right there: Manuel.*

MIGUEL. *No, sir. I am mine. And that contract means nothing to me. Because my name is Miguel.*

MIGUEL. I had signed his contract with the name he had told me to sign it with. Mr. Jack leaves with a choked line of words that I believe are curses. He cannot believe he has been beaten…by a shoe shiner.

More people are coming now; the game is ready to start. A man named Mr. Cogan is in those stands…searching for me.

And as I stand here, waiting to be seen, this ball feels heavy in my hand. It's like holding the weight of the world. And as I know now, with every piece of me, that this is more than a game. It's my life.

Endangered Species

by Jane Nicolaas

The Pleasant Valley Sexual Health Clinic sounds like a pleasant place. Seems like an okay place to spend the day with my girlfriend. But once we're inside, that thick hospital smell and the heavy silence tells me things in this valley are anything but pleasant.

Amy hasn't told me much of anything about the procedure. And from the way that the nurse looks at me through the glass, she's not going to include me in this either.

"You can pick her up at three," the nurse says with a rehearsed lilt in her voice.

"Oh. I was thinking I would stay."

The woman stares at me. I guess that's the wrong thing to do? I don't know. I guess I forgot my abortion etiquette handbook: *What to Expect When You're about to Stop Expecting*.

Nurse Ratchet is still scowling at me. I try a joke to circumvent some of the tension: "C'mon there's always womb for one more."

Not funny? Okay. Well, you can't win them all. She directs us down the hallway, and as we walk I mumble, "Though I walk through the Pleasant Valley of the shadow of death I will fear no evil nurses."

Amy smiles. It's the first time in weeks. You know, that's what I fell in love with first. A thin little smile like that. See, we were protesting, like college freshman do. And, you know, I don't even remember the cause – probably save the whales, or the pandas, or the rainforest, or something – but there we were yelling our guts out when she hits on me. Literally…she smashed me right in the head with her big "Vote No" sign. I took it as a sign. I think she meant to do it since she'd been yelling in my direction all day. When she turned and smiled, I just knew. You know, I *knew*. And that was how we started the walk toward this room.

Okay, I thought the hallway looked uninviting, but this waiting room makes that hallway look like it was lined with fleece and homemade cookies. This place is more than sterile. It's barren. Somewhat appropriate, I suppose.

And I have never met such a hostile silence. No, seriously, these women are burning holes into me with their eyes.

I am a stranger in a strange land. I feel like I need a khaki vest and a leather bound journal. "Reporting from behind enemy lines," and all that. I mean, I don't know any guys who have ever been to one of these things. But I think that's kinda why I want to be here. Sure, it's a woman's right to choose, but it's a guy's right to be supportive of that choice.

I wish I could explain that to all the judgmental eyes in this room. Because even though I don't know any of their stories, I am willing to bet that they just think I

did the same thing to Amy that was done to them. And in a way, I guess I did. I mean…she *is* pregnant. But you know, in spite of where we are, we are not here because of a bad decision, or a miscalculation, or a mistake. In fact, I think that the mistake is about to take place, but…

But that almost makes it worse, you know? Not knowing when everything between and inside of us changed…*somewhere* around two months ago…

The scream of a child brings me back out of my head.

Ironic.

There's a little kid, toddling around. Why he is here? Isn't it a little late, Mom? I mean, is there no statute of limitations in the Pleasant Valley?

Oh, good. He's screaming again. He's probably just crazy with boredom. There're no toys here? No, that'd be morbid.

I reach into my pocket and pull out a nickel. It's bright and shiny and immediately the little boy notices it. He stands and walks toward me on awkward, stubby legs. Securing the coin between my thumb and forefingers I quickly spin the nickel out into the middle of the table. The little boy squeals with delight. He picks up the nickel and waddles back to his mom. With pudgy hands he reaches up and shows her his treasure. She is not nearly as amused as he and I are. Note to self, frivolities not allowed in the waiting room.

Amy's hand slides onto my knee and squeezes. It's not like the times she'd laugh so hard at one of my jokes she'd need to lean on something to catch her breath. It's not like the time she wanted me to know that we were going to be okay despite the *very* unplanned pregnancy. No. This time she was telling me that I needed to stop. She's telling me to stop because I'm making bad decisions.

Suddenly a door on the left opens and that evil nurse is back. What does she want? Is she going to kick me out because I made a kid laugh? My eyes catch with Amy's and she has gone unbelievably pale.

Oh, God. This could be it.

I feel Amy's breath trap itself inside her lungs, and my body stiffens in protest. The nurse gives me a once over and calls out the name, "Gloria Bradley."

Gloria? Oh Hallelujah. I feel Amy's body breathe again. I try to touch her hand, but she pulls it away and rests her head in it. Her auburn hair creates a little curtain that hides her face from me.

You know, I was feeling like…like I don't know what I was feeling when we came. I thought I wanted to support Amy and help her through this, but she doesn't want me here.

She didn't even ask me. She just told me that she was pregnant and that we were going to get an abortion. I was the dutiful boyfriend who knew that it was her choice. It's a woman's right to choose…but it's a guy's right to be supportive of that choice. And I don't think I am.

I know that she doesn't want to get married. I know that we can't afford a

baby. I *know* that. But what if we could find a way to make it work? What if I could find a way to take her hand and tell her with a gentle squeeze that she was making a bad decision and she needed to stop? I could tell her that it was her body, but it was my decision, too. I could tell her that this wasn't what I wanted and that if she terminates this that she is terminating a part of me.

The door opens again. It's time.

Amy stands, and I'm paralyzed. I can't say anything or move. Amy doesn't look at me, she doesn't reach for me. She starts to move toward the door and away from me. My head is screaming any and every reason I don't want this to happen: it could have my mother's ability to cook; it could give us an excuse to go to Disney World; it could have my smile; it could have your eyes, Amy! It could have your eyes.

She's gone. And I am still perched on the edge of my seat waiting for her to notice I'm not with her. Where the hell is my "Vote No" sign?

All I can think about is that girl in the protest; she is where my life started and that seems really…ironic now. I am scared I'll never see that girl again. Is she going to be able to smile after this? Am I going to know, like I knew then? I don't know. All I know is that I am alone with strangers and judgmental eyes and white, sterile silence.

Prima Ballerina

by J. D. Taylor

My name is Athena Pallas, and I was meant to dance. And by the end of this class, you, too, will find that you were meant to dance. Unless you fail. In which case, you were not…meant…to dance. *(She pauses and smiles.)* Do not worry, it is only a joke. I am not a frightening woman unless you want for me to be one. A girl in my class some years ago did such a thing. She was somewhat large and quite clumsy on her feet. Her *jeté* was like a runner leaping over a hurdle and not clearing the bar. One particularly difficult afternoon, when I had quite tired of her oafish leaping and stomping about, I took her by the arm and I told her "This is not football practice! This is dance! And you, giant girl, are not meant to dance!" Her mother removed her from the class and sent me a very nasty letter, which I now have posted in my kitchen at home.

Let us begin. Five, six, seven, eight and one, and two…and three and…No, no, no. That is not the position. You must always be aware of your feet! If you do not know where your feet are, you will not know where your head is, and without your head and your feet you will never be able to dance! *(She calms herself.)* Sit, sit… Sometimes I think that you do not realize how good you have it. Your parents *want* you to dance. In Greece, in my childhood, there were many sporting pursuits for a young boy, but girls typically did not participate in athletics. Perhaps it is for the better, as the sports of the time were often played without any clothing, particularly wrestling. I had little interest in writhing naked on the ground with sexually-charged teenage boys who would probably have preferred each others' company over mine. So instead, I danced where I could and when I wanted to. My family disapproved—perhaps they wanted me to wrestle! But as people started to talk about me, those from elsewhere took note. It was not long before I fell in with a dance company, and soon after, a very handsome older man approached me following one of our performances. He was Russian, and he looked and spoke very different from all the people I had ever known. He invited me to perform for his friends, and a couple of weeks later I said goodbye to my home and became the Prima Ballerina of the Ballet Russe in Monaco. Much to my parents' chagrin, my childhood dream was reality.

A couple of years later, as I practiced my steps for our new production *Symphonie Fantastique,* I was summoned by the choreographer, Leonid Massine. This was 1936 and much of Europe was turning its eyes away from the arts as Hitler went about building concentration camps and intimidating neighbor countries. I thought this was foolish, for what is the world without the arts? We must always have painting and sculpture and theatre and dance, and that is why I am teaching these steps to you today. At the time, the world as a whole had not seen the evil this man could do, but we in Europe had taken some notice. Although I was not of Jewish or Gypsy heritage, I was afraid for my friends in the company with such families. You can imagine, then, my anger when I learned that Hitler, who was a lover of ballet, had asked Massine to bring the Ballet Russe to Berlin to perform for the premiers of the

Nazi party—and that Massine had agreed! I was furious and would have refused to go, but for the knowledge that the Fuhrer's requests were not optional. Even before the Blitzkrieg, we knew that Hitler was raising an army that, at a moment's notice, could and would take anything he wanted.

Now, you may have read that in those days women sometimes carried weapons under their clothes for self-defense. They were dainty things—guns and daggers not much bigger than those little phones you girls carry around. I do not understand why 10-year-olds must carry telephones with them at all times. When I was a girl we did not carry passenger pigeons. The cellular phone is a ridiculous thing. At any rate, I thought it would be a great thing to stop this man's terrorism before it could truly begin.

Had I done this a decade or even five years later, of course, the Gestapo would have had a woman to check under my costume, and I and my pistol would have been disposed of immediately. But this was in the early years of the Holocaust, and Hitler's paranoia had not yet reached its peak. So for the duration of *Symphonie Fantastique,* I kept one corner of my brain focused on the gun. If it should slip, or worse, discharge, my plot would be discovered and my heroism foiled. Perhaps due to the pressure I felt in the situation, my performance—and all of the other dancers'—were the best they had ever been. My pirouettes were perfect and tight, my *port de bras* was superb and at the end, just before the curtain…I looked up into the theatre boxes and saw him, smiling.

At the end of the dance, a young blond boy wearing a swastika approached. He told us that Hitler quite enjoyed the performance and wished to congratulate us for our work in person.

We followed the youngster into a chamber with tall ceilings. There were tables full of German delicacies, which mostly did not tempt me as I have never been one for strudel or *leibkuchen*—they are poor excuses for fresh baklava. A great number of people milled about with swastika armbands, and there—amidst the crowd—was Hitler. When he came to me his words were kind, but he was a bad actor—I could see in his eyes. He questioned my heritage. Perhaps he thought me a subject for his next camp. My heartbeat pounded so loud in my ears I could not hear his compliments; I could merely smile and nod, and the world seemed to stop turning around me.

When he turned to speak to another dancer, I saw my moment to strike. Slowly, I moved my hand under the folds of the costume. When my fingers found metal, I slipped the gun from its garter holster, raised it to the back of the Fuhrer's skull, and the next thing I and everyone else saw was a splash of grey as I shot the most evil man the world had ever known into nothingness. His lifeless body hit the hardwood floor with a dull thud, a much smaller noise than I'd thought it would be. No one else spoke, they just looked down in shock, then up at me with some mix of disbelief and…something resembling gratitude. For regardless of their beliefs, they knew that

I had just saved countless lives that would have been lost at the whims of this vile, pathetic excuse for a man.

At least, that is how it played in my mind. But in truth, as history and the memorials will tell you, I did not shoot Hitler. I did not carry the gun. I merely did as I was told because I could not overcome my fear of this man long enough to eliminate the source of that dread. *(straining to hear a student's question)* What if I had been stronger? You realize, little one, that I ask that of myself every day. And if I had an answer for myself, then I would give it to you as well. But I do not. Enough of that, let us continue with our lesson.

Lost Souls Starboard Ho!

by Kesha Williams

(Shawn is speaking to the audience, modern day. Angie's voice is merely a voice he hears from a time long behind this one. The tone is excited, as if this were preparation for a game to be played.)

SHAWN. *(pulls out of a box)* These shoes… were our little secret, Lynne's and mine.

LYNNE. A kind of game we played…

SHAWN. …when no one was looking. See, I used to drive this convertible.

LYNNE. White all over, outside and in. Like a giant metal cloud.

SHAWN. Now, it was a 1980's piece-a-crap, but…

LYNNE. …but the top rolled back…

SHAWN. …and that's all that mattered to a man under thirty. Anytime it was nice out, Lynne would get this smile on her face and ask…

LYNNE. Hey, dad, wanna go save some lost souls tonight?

SHAWN. We'd load into my convertible, roll back the roof and just…

BOTH. **…**go driving.

SHAWN. I was the captain and Lynne was always the lookout. Anytime she saw one of those shoes, you know, the ones you see just laying there in the road? The ones that make you wonder-

LYNNE. How did it get there? How do you just lose a shoe?

SHAWN. We called those shoes lost souls. And the game went like this: as soon as she saw a shoe, she'd scream out in the best pirate voice she could-

LYNNE. Ahoy, captain! Lost soul starboard ho!

SHAWN. I'd pull over and when it was safe we'd run out, snatch up the shoe and throw it in the trunk…

LYNNE. The place where lost souls are lost no more, right dad?

SHAWN. …and on we'd go… in search of more lost souls to save… The thing I loved most was the look on her face when she first spotted the shoe… the smile in her eyes, the look of, just, pure joy- like she really thought we were-

LYNNE. Buh-buh-buh-buh! Saving the world, one soul at a time!!!

SHAWN. I think that's the worst part about remembering the dead- remembering only what we want to remember and the desperate need to hold on to those few things that help us never to forget.

(Angela is in her own world, doing yoga. Shawn enters with a briefcase. Scene begins playful then grows into something more.)

SHAWN. Leave work early?

ANGELA. Decided not to go in today.

SHAWN. Oh. Did you call this time?

ANGELA. I emailed.

SHAWN. You emailed? *(beat)* What'd they say?

ANGELA. I haven't gotten back on to check.
SHAWN. Then how do y'know they got it?
ANGELA. I think they may have noticed that I wasn't there, Shawn.
SHAWN. Yeah, Angela. I'm just worried they may have noticed you weren't there four outta the past seven days. And two of the days you went in, you *were* home *by* lunch.
ANGELA. No, I *went* home *for* lunch. Big difference. Then… I don't know, I just decided to stay home.
SHAWN. Decided to stay or didn't want to leave?
ANGELA. Did I show you this new trivia game I uploaded onto my phone?
SHAWN. Downloaded.
ANGELA. What? What's the difference?
SHAWN. Upload is from small to large, not-
ANGELA. It doesn't really matter either way, does it? I got it on my phone. I saw the game on that one show- what's it called? The something-something show? Comes on that guy network?
SHAWN. *(playfully)* Oh yeah! That one! There's only one something-something show on that one guy network!
ANGELA. Oh, you know- not the one with the bald guy and the do-dids…it's the guy with the whatcha-ma-call it thingy? Oh, you know what I'm talking about, Shawn!
SHAWN. *(a little more agitated)* No, Angela, I don't know. You know why I don't know? Because I am working twelve hours a day and then trying to play the guess-what-Angela-did-today game using some hyper-intensive illogical multisyllabic code of whatmacallits and do-dids and something-somethings!
ANGELA. It's not illogical, Shawn. (*epiphany*) Mythbusters! No, Mannswers? I don't know. One of those guy shows that guys watch.
SHAWN. What time did you get in bed last night?
ANGELA. Oh, it was late and you were sleeping, so I just slept on the sofa till the alarm went off. I watched some movie on that one channel, the one all the tear-jerker made-for-TV movies that prey on the unstable hormones of the women watching? Eh, yeah, I fell asleep with a snout fulla tears, cryin' over some terminally ill kid that never really existed. *(laughs)* It's silly.
SHAWN. No, it's cathartic.
ANGELA. *(brushing him off)* Yeah, yeah. Anyway, I think I'm going to hop in the shower. I feel so sticky…
SHAWN. It's nice out. You wanna take a drive? We could talk…
ANGELA. Shawn, I really need a shower before I do anything.
SHAWN. Okay.
ANGELA. Love you. *(speaking to herself)* Damn, what was that show called? Man-something…

LYNNE. Ahoy, captain! Lost shoe starboard ho!
SHAWN. Lynne and I used to make up whole stories about the lost souls, how

they got lost.
LYNNE. This flip flop used to be made of solid wood. You couldn't even put your foot in it. Then his dad, who happened to be the town cobbler, wished upon a star and poof—a real flip flop—just like that.
SHAWN. But the real fun was figuring out how they managed to get lost.
LYNNE. But the flip flop felt it was time to do more than just flippity flop through life. So, out he went. He was on his way to boot camp when… ooops. Got caught up with the wrong stiletto and became a naughty little zapato. And here we find him. Lost. And alone.
SHAWN. She usually stole at least part of her story from some sort of movie she'd seen.
LYNNE. I think we did a good thing here tonight, dad. Because of us, another lucky soul has been saved. We are saving the world-
SHAWN. -one soul at a time.

ANGELA. *(Angie enters the room.)* Where were you last night?
SHAWN. Where were you?
ANGELA. I was where I was supposed to be. Here. Waiting for you.
SHAWN. Where?
ANGELA. What?
SHAWN. Where were you? Laying in the bath like a zombie? Sleeping on the couch? Watching some stupid movie?
ANGELA. Never mind what I was doing, Shawn! Where were you?
SHAWN. I was out, Angie.
ANGELA. Where?
SHAWN. Nowhere. Just out.
ANGELA. I am going to ask you one more time, where were-
SHAWN. I was driving, okay?
ANGELA. Just driving? Just out… driving around?
SHAWN. Yeah. Just driving around.
ANGELA. I am sitting at home, worried out of my mind. Calling you. You don't answer. And you are… just out. Driving.
SHAWN. I am surprised you notice, Angie.
ANGELA. Of course I noticed! What do you think, that I don't-
SHAWN. I don't want to talk about this.
ANGELA. No, I want to talk. I want to talk, Shawn.
SHAWN. Six months, Angie. Six months and now you're ready to talk?! Well, I'm sorry, but I'm done talking. I've talked to my mom, your mom, my sister, my psychiatrist. I have talked to every single person I know. but the one person who should have been there talking…
ANGELA. That's not fair!
SHAWN. The one person would should have been there, crying with me.
ANGELA. I couldn't…
SHAWN. You couldn't? Couldn't what? Mourn your own daughter?
ANGELA. Why are you so angry, Shawn? I didn't kill her! I wasn't the one out with her the night she…

SHAWN. Don't.

ANGELA. Don't what?

SHAWN. Don't blame me. Don't. Blame. Me.

ANGELA. I have talked, Shawn. And I have cried. Just not to you. Do you hear me? Not to you.

SHAWN. I don't understand.

ANGELA. I can't, Shawn. I can't look at you. And when I do look, its not you looking back at me. It's this… stranger, just staring right through me. I talk, okay? I get online. I post. I connect to those people and they listen to me.

SHAWN. They're strangers, too, Angie.

ANGELA. They're strangers, but at least they've always been strangers. It hurts when I look at you… and I don't know you. My husband.

SHAWN. You know me.

ANGELA. No, I don't. I don't know anything about you. I don't know how you feel about any of this. You say that I haven't talked in six months…. But I didn't just lose my daughter. I lost my husband back in that accident, too.

SHAWN. I'm right here.

ANGELA. What about your trunk?

SHAWN. What?

ANGELA. The trunk of your car? I found all these…

SHAWN. Shoes.

ANGELA. Shoes. Tons of them. Just single shoes. They're not even yours. Some are kids, some are women's… and not a single one has a match. Where did they come from?

SHAWN. Did you touch them?

ANGELA. What do you mean?

SHAWN. Did you touch them?

ANGELA. Why?

SHAWN. Did you touch them?!

ANGELA. Yes. I did. I… I threw them out.

SHAWN. No. You… you threw them… where? Where did you put them?

ANGELA. The garbage man already-

SHAWN. Those were hers! They were hers! All of them!

ANGELA. They were whose?

SHAWN. Lynne's! They were Lynne's.

ANGELA. What?

SHAWN. It was this game we played. This… they were lost souls. We saved them. We…

ANGELA. Is that how she was hit? Shawn, is that how she was hit?

SHAWN. Yes. Yes…

ANGELA. Oh my… I can't… Oh my…

SHAWN. I didn't jump out fast enough. Angie hopped out, ran. I yelled her name. Tried to stop her… but the car was speeding and…she didn't even see it. Didn't have time to… She knew better. We talked

about it so many times. Wait for daddy. Wait for daddy. The lost souls can wait. But, but she wanted to save it.

ANGELA. I don't understand. Shawn, I don't understand.

SHAWN. It's my fault, Angie. It's all…all of it's my fault.

ANGELA. Look at me. Look at me, Shawn. This is not your fault. It was an accident. You loved Lynne. You loved her more than a person should be able to love. She knew that. Do you know how jealous I was of you? How jealous I was that you had that with her? You had something that I could never have with our daughter? A bond.

SHAWN. She trusted me to protect her. You trusted me. And I lost her. I lost our little girl.

ANGELA. No, you saved her. I really believe that. For ten years, she was the most giving, loving little girl I've ever known. She was spirited, yes, but she was amazing. That was all you, Shawn. She was a product of you.

SHAWN. I feel so… lost. I don't know how to… feel. How to live anymore.

ANGELA. Then live for her. How do you think she would want to see you? Like this? Mourning her forever? Or living. Smiling. Celebrating her memory…

SHAWN. I just… I miss her.

ANGELA. And you should. I miss her, too…

SHAWN. You smell nice.

ANGELA. I put on perfume. I figured… I need to get up and around sometime. You not coming home last night… really woke me up, I guess.

SHAWN. Good. I missed you.

ANGELA. I'm sorry about the shoes. I didn't know…

SHAWN. It's okay. It was time…

ANGELA. I have an idea.

SHAWN. What?

ANGELA. Let's go… driving.

SHAWN. I can't.

ANGELA. I'll drive. You just… ride.

SHAWN. Okay… *(smiles)* okay.

LYNNE. Ahoy, captain! Lost soul starboard ho!

SHAWN. Sometimes, remembering… takes letting go. Otherwise, we forget what's really important.

LYNNE. Pull over, daddy! It's right there, right in the middle of the road!

SHAWN. We can't mourn death forever. We can't hold onto… things.

LYNNE. Bet I get it first!

SHAWN. Things don't anchor the ones we love into our memories.

LYNNE. Watch me, daddy!

SHAWN. Love. Love is what helps us remember. Not our loss, but the life we never want to lose. It's the memories that help us…

LYNNE. Buh-buh-buh-buh! Saving the world, one soul at a time!!!

SHAWN. …help us to never forget.

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SpeechGeek
806 Brownstone Way
Bowling Green, KY 42104
thegeek@speechgeek.com

Season Eight: Fall 2010
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ISSN Number 1545-9209



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